Immunisation and the media

We rely on the media to provide us with information. However, we need to be aware of how the information is being presented, and whether all the information is being reported. How often have you seen a news story saying that everything is all right? Good news stories are not very dramatic, so we don't see them in the news very often.

The topic of immunisation is one that people have different opinions about. Immunisation can save millions of lives by preventing the spread of disease. However, there have also been stories of immunisation having terrible consequences, such as brain damage, in children. These stories may sometimes be reported more widely than the success stories.

It is important to study the news and history while also asking questions such as:

- What is the risk of the vaccine?
- What is the risk of the disease it is trying to stop?
- Is the risk just to my child or others as well?

Reading the news in this way allows individuals to form a considered opinion.

☞ **1** A local headline read 'Children ill after National Vaccination Program'. As a result, worried parents asked questions at the local medical clinic. Match the answers given to each question below.

Questions	Answers
How sick are the children?	Children used to become extremely ill and many died.
Are the sick children local or from all over Australia?	No, it is my professional opinion that it is the common cold.
Are children who didn't have the vaccination also sick?	Several unvaccinated children are also sick.
How serious was the illness being immunised against before wide-spread vaccinations began?	Several local children are sick but so are children from a wider area.
Is it the doctor's opinion that the vaccination made the children sick?	The children are only slightly ill.

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